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Ubuntu in South African Education

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DECLARATION

I declare that ***Ubuntu* in South African education** is my own work and that all the sources that I have used or quoted have been indicated and acknowledged by means of complete references.

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Abstract

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***Ubuntu* in South African education**

Ubuntu lies at the heart of the African way of life and impacts on every aspect of people's well-being. This paper seeks to explore the notion of being human by grounding discussions around the concept of what is generally referred to as *Ubuntu* in South African education and society. The issue of discipline in schools or in education is selected as a way to demonstrate the concept of *Ubuntu* mostly amongst learners and teachers or either the school environment. *Ubuntu* is actually regarded as the soul force that drives almost every facet of societal life in African societies and that create the relationship between the African community .In this paper I will be mostly focusing on *Ubuntu* in education or rather in South African schools. This paper seeks to understand how *Ubuntu* impacts on discipline in South African schools. *Ubuntu* in the South African context or society is seen as the act of being human, caring, sympathy, empathy, forgiveness or any values of humanness towards others. *Ubuntu* is a capacity in South African culture that expresses compassion, reciprocity, dignity, harmony and humanity in the interests of building and maintaining a community with justice and mutual caring. The consequences of failure to embrace *Ubuntu* in South African Schools manifest itself through learner's indiscipline and staff not respecting each other. The purpose of this paper is to place the reader in South African society and introduce the concept of *Ubuntu* as the Philosophy of the society in relation to education.

Introduction

Ubuntu is defined by Letseka.(2011) as a form of human engagement that allows for critical thinking, non-domination and the optimal development of human relationships. *Ubuntu* means that each individual's humanity is ideally expressed in relationship with others, *Ubuntu* is then to be aware of one's own being but also of one's duties towards one's neighbour. According to Mbigi.(1997) “*Ubuntu* is a concrete manifestation of the interconnectedness of human beings; it is the embodiment of South African culture and lifestyle”.

In schools we say the School outcomes are influenced by *Ubuntu* personality values such as caring, forgiveness, sharing, equality, sympathy, empathy, compassion, respect, tolerance, humanness and harmony for others. Mbigi.(1997) states that where pupils have more of the above qualities there is greater desire to learn, every school has its own unique culture. According Mbigi.(1997) The school culture gives the school its unique identity. Culture represents the schools way of life and the way things are done. Mbigi. (1997) many studies have revealed a link between school culture and its effectiveness, school development, academic achievement and learner discipline.

According to Letseka.(2011) The school culture influences how people do things in the school. The issue of discipline in schools or in education is selected as a way to demonstrate the concept of *Ubuntu* mostly amongst learners and teachers or either all the bodies in the school environment. Letseka.(2011) *Ubuntu* is actually regarded as the soul force that drives almost every facet of societal life in African societies and creates the relationship between the African communities. *Ubuntu* in society emphasize the principles such as, Respect for people through cooperative human activity and recognition of human vulnerabilities ,Seeks individual and communal good to enhance the prosperity of others, the self and the community and a” person is a person through other persons

Ubuntu in South African Education

Ubuntu in education is usually something that begins from the school leaders (Principal, Teachers) because most of the successful schools or academically good schools are those schools that are currently embracing *Ubuntu* leadership for example; the school treat all learners equally or the school practice the

values of *Ubuntu*. According to Letseka.(2011) We can see the school on whether is practicing *Ubuntu* because what is happening in in the schools is a true reflection of *Ubuntu*. Letseka.(2011) says the philosophy of *Ubuntu* in South African Education is reflected by the School discipline to ensure safety of the staff and learners' and secondly creating the environment conducive to teaching and learning. Letseka.(2011) Sustainable development depends on harnessing the energy of the majority meaning the school work together with community, staff and all the leaners to practice *Ubuntu*. The focus in teaching, learning and professional development irrespective of field needs to be grounded on notions of *Ubuntu*, Leadership through *Ubuntu* is perceived as of collective agency.Letseka.(2011) states that In the case of education it means adoption of a strong community-school partnership where all stakeholders such as teachers, learners, school leaders, parents, community and local and central government co-participate in shaping and implementing of learning programmes.

For example the teacher and school staff should respect, care for themselves and then care for all the learners in the school irrespective of their background or circumstances.Letseka.(2011) The consequences of *Ubuntu* when applied to the school context especially in areas of school discipline. The high performing school is likely to be characterised by the presence of *Ubuntu* practice in it. Letseka.(2011) Generally the level of school discipline reflects the presence and the absence of *Ubuntu* in the school and the surrounding community. Msila.(2008) when the schools embrace *Ubuntu* we witness a disciplined student body in it. Consequently, the type of leadership that leads to improved school performance is related to the presence or absence of *Ubuntu* in them. Msila.(2008) the ill-disciplined student body, on the other hand, shows the failure to embrace the principles of *Ubuntu*. Hence, the absence of *Ubuntu* would result in undesirable outcomes in schools.

***Ubuntu* in education**

Letseka.(2011) *Ubuntu* in education is considered to be African cultural capitals that provide indigenous knowledge which is actually important for integrating into our African conception of inclusion which in turn promote inclusivity, equality and social justice in our education system. Letseka.(2011) says the purpose of education is to free the minds of the oppressed in order to destroy social classes and create

one human consciousness within the society. The education is aimed at developing a conception of education that contribute towards imagination deliberation and responsibility, actions that help towards enhancing justice in educative relations, specifically in relation to African Education. *Ubuntu* in education make learners to acknowledge humanity in themselves and others.

The school should encourage learners to work cooperatively through sharing and engaging with others in the classroom. *Ubuntu* in schools or in education is described as an inclusive approach which calls for dignity and respect in our mutual relationships with others in education, classroom or school. Broodryk.(2006:32) states that *Ubuntu* is actually the The communities that fully embrace and value humanism, understood as “*Ubuntu*”, It is assumed that persons in such communities would strive to treat others with a sense of “*Ubuntu*”, which entails treating them with fairness, so the learners and the school staff are part of the community which results in embracing *Ubuntu* in the school.

(Broodryk.2006:32) states that the values of *Ubuntu* and human dignity follow the practices of compassion, kindness and respect which are at the very core of making schools the places where the culture of teaching and the culture of learning take place, making the school a place of achievement rather than places of conflict and pain. Broodryk.(2006:15) states that the education or school as a whole reflects the values and beliefs that the society considers worthy, so the school transmit those values, ethics as the school staff and learners are part of the society. Values are the integral part of the society and society understand itself and judges its worth through value system by taking education of individual into consideration. The core values of *Ubuntu* in education as described by Broodryk.(2006:32) provide a supportive basis or the frame of reference from which both teacher and learner engage in the assessment process. According to Letseka.(2011) the whole education process centres around *Ubuntu* as a philosophy or set of ethical principles that capture the belief system of the South Africans according to which people take responsibility to others and accept the authority and guidance of others in order to progress. *Ubuntu* in education gives learners the primacy to humanness and adopt more holistic view in learners instead of reducing their abilities or potential. As identified by Government Gazzette.(NO.20844) the teacher in the school that practices *Ubuntu* should be competent,

caring and dedicated to provide equal and respective education to all learners no matter how is their background or circumstances.

***Ubuntu* understood directly by literature**

Many literatures understand *Ubuntu* directly as the the actions that actually symbolizes the humanness between human being, according to other literatures *Ubuntu* includes the essential human virtues; compassion and humanity. *Ubuntu* is viewed as the way the person treat others or shows a caring behaviour towards others. According Broodryk.(2006:4) states that *Ubuntu* personality is a reference to the ideal human being as it is manifested in the living of the ancient *Ubuntu* values. A person living according to *Ubuntu* virtues should reveal the values such as a kind person, generous, living in harmony, friendly, modest, helpful, humble and happy towards others and the other value which very important and which shows or reveal humanness within a person is to treat people equally irrespective of their background or circumstances.

Ubuntu can directly be understood taking into consideration the values and principles of social justice, social justice is in a general sense related to the principles of equality, equity and fairness, towards groups or individuals who have been marginalized, disadvantaged or excluded economically, politically and socially, based on constructs such as race, social class, language, gender, religion, age, ability and sexual preference which shows the values of *Ubuntu* as well.so according to my opinion I can say *Ubuntu* and social justice are hand to hand processes, where *Ubuntu* is embraced ,obviously there is Social justice.Broodryk.(2006:4)states that one of the goals of social justice is social equality which refers to the full participation and inclusion of everyone in a society's major institutions such as schools, churches and other organisations, and the socially supported substantive opportunity for all to develop and exercise their capacities and realize their choices. For example; if the school is having learners from different background such as different religion, social class or ethnic in the same class the school treat all the learners equally and equal opportunities are given to those learners and the respect of learners' humanity is offered to all learners that simply shows that the school is embracing *Ubuntu*. "No Future Without Forgiveness" as indicated by (Truth and Reconciliation Commission) those words of truth and

reconciliation commission promote *Ubuntu* and reveal the values of *Ubuntu* in them, due to the fact that forgiveness is one of the values of *Ubuntu*, which in school context mean that there will be no discipline or there will be conflict with the leadership of the school without forgiveness. Broodryk.(2006:4) states that the value of *Ubuntu* is to make the relationships between learners and break down the barriers in diverse school settings which are also the goals for social justice in education. Broodryk.(2006:4) states that the fact is that *Ubuntu* offer the opportunity for people to engage with each other in the community is also contained by diversity and social justice goals that is how the white paper 6 and government gazette or other government documents consider or define *Ubuntu*. Broodryk.(2006:4) says humanism is used in our schools to refer to a philosophy that sees human needs, interests and dignity as of fundamental importance and concern.

***Ubuntu* understood indirectly by literature**

Indirectly other literature understand *Ubuntu* as discussed in Government Gazette .(NO.20884) the educator will practise and promote a critical, committed and ethical attitude towards developing a sense of respect and responsibility towards others. The educator will uphold the constitution and promote democratic values and practices in schools and society. Within the school, the educator will demonstrate an ability to develop a supportive and empowering environment for the learner and respond to the educational and other needs of learners and fellow educators. According to Government Gazzette.(NO.20844) described that the teacher in the school that practices *Ubuntu* should be competent, caring and dedicated to provide equal and respective education to all learners no matter how is their background or circumstances.

The Curriculum documents such as CAPS and NCS reveal the understanding of *Ubuntu* by including the values of *Ubuntu* in their principles, purposes and aims. The concept of *Ubuntu* is also understood indirectly through the inclusivity in education and society; the Constitution of republic of South Africa (Act 108 of 1996) states founded our democratic state and common citizenship on the values of human dignity, the achievement of equality and the advancement of human rights and freedoms. These values

summon all of us to take up the responsibility and challenge of building a humane and caring society for everyone which also emphasize the concept of *Ubuntu* with the society by including everyone within the society no matter of their .the white paper 6 of inclusive education reveal the indirect understanding of *Ubuntu*, the white paper 6 understand *Ubuntu* as acknowledging the fact that all children and youth can learn and that accepting and respecting the fact that all learners are different in some way and have different learning needs which are equally valued. The (Department of Education. Education White Paper 6: (2011), states that teacher should acknowledge and respect differences in learners, whether due to age, gender, ethnicity, language, class, disability or HIV status, the principles from white paper 6 of inclusive education contain the values of *Ubuntu* and is actual revealing *Ubuntu* indirectly.(white paper 6 Special need education:2011) also emphasize the values of *Ubuntu* by respecting others difference and including them in the education system.

***Ubuntu* and curriculum policy documents**

Department of Education (DoE). (2002)National curriculum Statement (**NCS**) and Curriculum assessment policy statement (**CAPS**) have the general aims and principles that link or reveal *Ubuntu* in them. We actually say the whole education process centres around *Ubuntu* as a philosophy or set of ethical principles that capture the belief system of the South Africans according to which people take responsibility to others and accept the authority and guidance of others in order to progress. The Documents support and put the values of *Ubuntu* into practice. Both curriculum documents principles emphasize the values of *Ubuntu*, NCS and CAPS (Department of Education (DoE). 2002) gives an expression to what is regarded to be knowledge, skills and values worth learning. Both curriculum documents ensure that learners acquire and apply knowledge and the skills in a meaningful ways to their lives.

The principles of CAPS and NCS are emphasizing the values of *Ubuntu*, whereby this principle is included in curriculum documents, (Department of Education (DoE). 2002)social transformation that ensures the educational imbalances of the past are readdressed and equal educational opportunities are provided for every individual, that principle also support or link with one of social justice goal which is

equality. (Department of Education (DoE). 2002)The second purpose of NCS is also somehow fulfilling the *Ubuntu* values which emphasize the active and critical learning that encourage active learning approach. The principle of stated by curriculum documents; equality ,kindness, and other human rights equality, inclusivity environmental and social justice, infusing principles and practices human rights, all the stated principles are the core values of *Ubuntu* and others are social justice goals, others such as inclusivity are also contained in white paper 6 which actually support the humanness. The purpose of the curriculum documents support the fact of inclusivity in education which is one of core value of *Ubuntu*; as it (Department of Education (DoE). 2002) says learners will be equipped irrespective of their socio- economic background, race, gender, physical ability, intellectual ability with knowledge and values necessary for self-fulfilment and meaning of participation in society.

Ubuntu manifest itself in education

According to Msila.(2008) the School outcomes are influenced by *Ubuntu* personality values that are embraced within the school. Where pupils have more *Ubuntu* qualities there is greater desire to learn. *Ubuntu* manifest itself whereby a teacher or a leader listen to the learners stories. When *Ubuntu* is manifesting itself in our schools or education the teacher encourage learners for critical thinking and self-reflectivity, the teacher and education department usually engage with relevant concepts for change in education system. Msila.(2008) states that the discipline and togetherness in schools underpin *Ubuntu* as it is the learners behaviour towards their peers and adults that shows dignity or lack of it.*Ubuntu* is revealed by teamwork in the areas of education, for example where the school have the crisis such as bullying, truancy, then the collective efforts which involve parents, teachers and the senior management team (SMT) to combat the discipline problems reveals itself, once this collective effort is achieved, the improvement is likely to happen; that is how I can explain *Ubuntu* manifesting itself in schools because if there is no *Ubuntu* there will be no teamwork.

If there is *Ubuntu* at school there is always the effective discipline that contribute to a school's effectiveness and involves keeping good order, consistently enforcing fair, clear and well-understood rules in that particular school. Discipline is always well in the schools where is *Ubuntu*, the staff respect

their selves, each other and learners humanity. Msila.(2008) states that the consequences of *Ubuntu* manifestation in the school context especially in areas of school discipline it result in good school discipline, high performing school is likely to be characterised by the presence of *Ubuntu*. The level of school discipline reflects the presence of *Ubuntu*. According to Msila.(2008) When schools embrace *Ubuntu* we witness disciplined learners. Consequently, the type of leadership that leads to improved school performance is related to the presence or absence of *Ubuntu* within them; for example in *Ubuntu* embracing school there is respect between teacher and learner and the school is well seen by well diversity of learners from different areas. According to Msila.(2008) School leadership that practice *Ubuntu* is respectful of its community partnership.

Ubuntu not manifesting itself in education

An ill-disciplined learners, shows the failure to embrace the principles of *Ubuntu*. The absence of *Ubuntu* would result in undesirable outcomes in schools. If there is no *Ubuntu* values there will be no effective and efficient management of teaching and learning in schools. The school without *Ubuntu* there is no respect for one another which inhibit trust among learners, teachers and parents. There would always be the high indiscipline from learners to teachers and parents. The learner's behaviour towards their peers and adults will not show any human dignity. Acts of indiscipline by students and staff defeat the aims and purpose of education. (Msila.2008) No meaningful learning can take place in a chaotic environment. For example; in schools there are cases where learners are alleged to have murdered other learners in school premises; meaning due to absence of *Ubuntu* the Schools have become unsafe environments that are not conducive to learning and teaching. Msila(2008) What is happening in some of the schools is a reflection of the transition from *Ubuntu* to a thing. Msila.(2008)states that without *Ubuntu* in education people often treat one another not as human beings but as things. There is a prevalence of crime, violence, hooliganism and indiscipline in schools that do not embrace *Ubuntu*.

Relationship between Ubuntu and the achievement of social justice in education

Young, I.M. (1990) states that in the schools or society that embraces *Ubuntu* the values of social justices such as the promotion of values of diversity amongst race, gender and social class, the improvement of relationships between learners, breaking down barriers in diverse school settings and addressing stereotypes with regard to race, gender, ability, language, accent are always present. *Ubuntu* is a weapon used by schools or society to challenge the inequality and injustices. In order to fully realise the spirit of *Ubuntu* in education, According to Young, I.M. (1990) it is good to engage members of our communities. This is the first step towards achieving the values of being the caring nation, with recognised democratic values and a social justice system that is based on equality, non-racism, non-sexism and human dignity in education. *Ubuntu* means that a person is a person through other people and *Ubuntu* societies develop mechanism to maintain social cohesion and harmony then we say *Ubuntu* lead to the achievement of social justice in education, for example; the teacher in the school that practice *Ubuntu* respect and value and include all the learners' needs. *Ubuntu* is linked with the social justice through humanness. *Ubuntu* in society is actually recognised by what is morally good for individuals and community is determined by the dignity, respect and contentment to enhance the prosperity of others which are also the goals for social justice. According to Young, I.M. (1990) the school that practice social justice goals give respect to religion, ethnic and culture of learners and teachers encourage equal learner participation.

The goals of *Ubuntu* are similar to social justice goals, social justice goals emphasize equality among all learners the goal is linking with *Ubuntu* value of equality. Young, I.M. (1990) states that the teacher advocate social justice in education through social justice and *Ubuntu* values inclusivity and human rights. Teacher addresses the forms of social justice in class through practice to address and deal with discrimination. For the school to practice social justice values such as respect, inclusion they are first influenced by *Ubuntu* values. According to Young, I.M. (1990) The goals of social justice such as promotion of values of diversity amongst race gender and class; the improvement of relationships between learners; and Breaking down barriers in diverse school settings are all supporting the values of

Ubuntu. The main goal of social justice is social equality which means the full participation and inclusion of everyone in a society's schools.

Conclusion

Ubuntu is the principle of caring for each other's well-being and a spirit of mutual support. Each individual's humanity is ideally expressed through his or her relationship with others and theirs in turn through recognition of the individual's humanity. Msila.(2008) states that *Ubuntu* means that the people are people through other people. It also acknowledged that both the rights and responsibilities of every citizen in promoting individual and social well-being is simply a way of living and being that allows our basic goodness to come forth. True *Ubuntu* recognises differences and hence always strives to strike consensus rather than impose a universal sameness on the issues.(Msila.2008) This is why for instance in schools, leadership plays an important role in creating an environment that is conducive to both teaching and learning. *Ubuntu* values can play a critical role in terms of effective and efficient of teaching and learning in schools. According to Msila.(2008) There five key social values known as the collective finger theory that underpins *Ubuntu* philosophy; survival, solidarity, compassion, respect and dignity, *Ubuntu* puts emphasis on how an individual contributes to the good of the collective values. Im concluding by saying successful schools embrace *Ubuntu* from leadership to learners and parents.

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